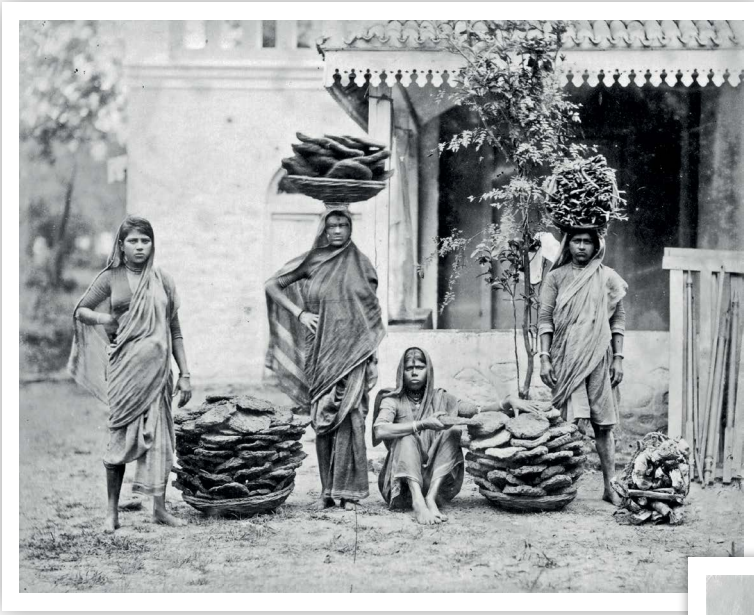


PHOTOGRAPHY ▼

PORTRAIT OF A PEOPLE

Colonial ethnographic photography and its contentious legacy are the subject of a new exhibition at ***DAG Delhi***

Delhi's DAG has announced a new photo exhibition that will run parallel to the India Art Fair (IAF). *Typecasting: Photographing the Peoples of India 1855-1920* is one of the largest collections of colonial-era ethnographic photography, bringing together almost 200 rare photographs and photographic material (prints, cabinet cards, albums, et al). The exhibition has been curated by Dr Sudeshna Guha, professor of History and Archaeology at the Shiv Nadar Institute of Eminence, and will be on display at Delhi's Bikaner House between January 30 and February 15.

It was common for British writers, scientists and intellectuals to embark upon large-scale documentation and categorisation projects in colonial India. Indeed, DAG itself has previously organised exhibitions that collected colonial-era botanical drawings and sketches of Indian monuments commissioned by the British. The primary purpose of these initiatives was Orientalist studies and, therefore, the processes therein reflected that bias. "Looking back, it is obvious that this process was problematic on various levels," says DAG CEO and managing director Ashish Anand ahead of the exhibition's opening.

From the Lepchas and the Bhutias in the Northeast to the Todas of the Nilgiris, to the indigenous people of Chhotanagpur, the exhibition attempts to cast a wide net and highlight the diversity of India. Among the subjects are rich Gujarati and Parsi merchants, barbers and carpenters, coolies and nautch girls. The sheer range of professions covered shows us that these photographs were also a way of defining socio-economic groups. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

From Jan. 30 to Feb. 15, Bikaner House, Delhi



THE COLONIAL GAZE G.R. Lambert & Co.'s Untitled (Indian family in Singapore); top, Edward Taurines's 'Manure Dryers'



STILL MOMENT 'At Wayside Inn, Bombay', Jussawalla photographed by Horace Ove

EXHIBITION ▼

RARE WINDOW

A selection of artefacts from *Adil Jussawalla*'s personal collection offers a peek into the poet's world

Presented by The Guild at the Kerala Museum, *Enlightenment from an Unlikely Envelope: Archives of Adil Jussawalla*, running until March, offers a rare chance to encounter one of the most significant figures in Indian poetry in English through the intimate evidence of a life in writing. Curated by Deeptha Achar and Chithra K.S., the exhibition brings together a small but evocative selection from Jussawalla's personal collection: texts, manuscripts, scrapbooks, notes, lists, photographs, books, newspaper clippings, poems, plants and other traces shaped by the contours of his private world.

Jussawalla's stature rests on notable volumes such as *Land's End* (1962) and *Missing Person* (1976), but his influence also extends through his role as editor of *New Writing in India* and as a founding member of the poets' collective publishing house, Clearing House. The exhibition reflects this breadth, revealing how the literary and the everyday often share the same space.

A particularly compelling thread is the show's exploration of Jussawalla's photographic practice. As a young man, he was rarely seen without a camera. Intimately bound to Bombay and later Mumbai, many of the materials suggest entry points into the city's literary and artistic landscape as it evolved from the 1970s onwards.

For scholars, the archive is an invaluable site of research. For general visitors, it offers something equally vital: an encounter with the quiet, human labour of attention from which literature is made. ■

— Nikhil Sardana

The exhibition is on view until Mar. 31 at the Kerala Museum, Kochi